

REVIEWS / TOP PICKS

KRONOS PRO LTD Turntable – The Review

By Dato' Danon Han on Wednesday, June 21, 2017



The Name of the Titan

Kronos or **Cronus** is the name of the supreme god in *Greek mythology*. I asked 'Analogue Maven', **Louis Desjardins** why he used the name for his brand. His simple answer to me is that the Greek mythology is filled with music and their love for it. They sang song and made music about their gods, heroes and important events throughout times. There are already a few models of audio products employed the name of gods from the Greek mythology. *TriangleArt* named their cartridges, *Zeus* and *Apollo*.





Kronos is thy Name!

The Kronos turntable is the first which employ **two platters rotating at counter direction** to achieve a '**balance**'. I talked to the designer and founder of Kronos turntable about his design and concept.

Can you imagine that originally he wanted to named his turntable to one that relate to 'balance'. He shared to me that his initial impression after hearing the first note played from his turntable is "*how balance the whole presentation was from the single tone to the whole picture*".

My first session with the Kronos Pro Limited Production (hereinafter referred to as **Kronos Pro Ltd**) turntable in my set up was a limited one.

Thus a full review was not possible. I do not enjoy the idea of penning down my experience of a component's performance with only two weeks. I prefer at least two months to write a full review. The local distributor was not in a position to loan me their flagship turntable for that pro-long period to complete a full review.

So, my questions then is whether should I purchase another turntable at this time and if so, is this the turntable to have? I already owned an extra *Graham Phantom 2* tonearm and *eleven (11) cartridges* that I wish to play or hear for some times. I knew that I will get another turntable to accommodate my collection above. To be frank, I was contemplating a bigger and better turntable compare to those I owned; the *TechDas Air Force One*, the *Clearaudio Statement* and the *Linn LP12 Lingo-ed*. Earlier I sold my *SME 30/2* and *TWA AC-1* with the *Night Raven three (3) motors* system for the *TechDas*.

That is one decision that did not haunt me.

I did not give any reply or confirmation to the local distributor (currently by **James Chin of YY Audio, Malaysia** 🇲🇾) when I called them to collect the 'demo' Kronos Pro Ltd turntable.



Why?

I already knew that the Kronos Pro Ltd turntable is special and to my ears, definitely ***much better than the SME 30/2 and the TWA AC-1***.

My 'but' is that is it better than my rest (my collection of turntables)?

Then I realized the other possible option(s) can cost several times the price of the Kronos Pro Ltd turntable.

Another two weeks later, I placed my order for the Kronos Pro Ltd turntable with the arm board ready for my *Vertere Reference tonearm*.



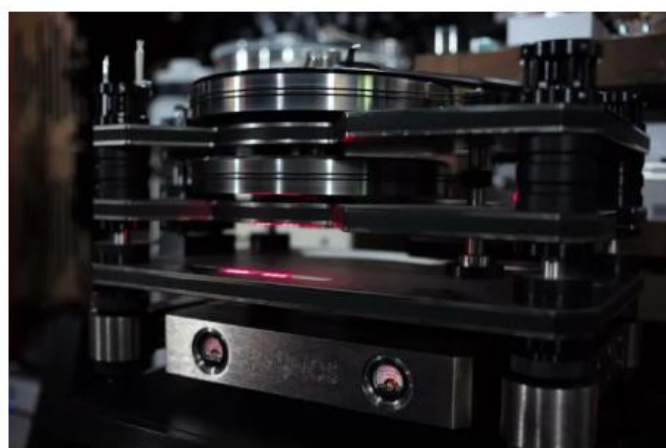
Possibly the most expensive Kronos Pro Ltd turntable combo?

I contacted The Analog Guru, *Touraj Moghaddam* (remember *The Roksan TMS?*), the founder and chief designer of *Vertere Acoustics*, of my intention to place his prized design, the Vertere Reference tonearm on the Kronos Pro Ltd.

He sent me an SME adapter for the Kronos arm board for easy installation.

Louis Desjardins was on hand to assist in the transfer of the Vertere Reference tonearm together with the attached *TriangleArt Apollo MC cartridge* from my TechDas Air Force One to the Kronos Pro Ltd turntable. I wanted the listening of the Kronos Pro Ltd to be on equal ground with the TechDas Air Force One.

After the installation and some fine adjustments of the tonearm and cartridge, I told Louis the price of the Vertere Reference tonearm which is almost equal to the Kronos Pro Ltd. I added that this combination of the Kronos Pro Ltd turntable with the Vertere Reference tonearm is *possibly the most expensive combo for his set up*. Louis did not argue with me on that point.



The Canadian's first response.

Louis has been to my place before when he first installed the Kronos Pro Ltd that resulted in my first impression of it (at *Mono & Stereo then...which I am no more attach to*).

He knows his turntable well and what it is capable of. At this second visit, the new elements are the Vertere Reference tonearm, TriangleArt Apollo MC cartridge and the *Telos Audio Ground Noise Reducers*. I knew from Louis' facial expression that he is listening to his Kronos Pro Ltd turntable performing and singing very differently.

After some tracks played, the designer asked what have I done to my system that it sounds so much improved from his first encounter! I knew how great the Vertere Reference tonearm is (the review available [here](#)) and how much it can elevate the analogue set up performance, especially given a great cartridge like the TriangleArt Apollo MC (the review available [here](#)) and an ultra quiet and stable turntable.

Then and there I knew what the Kronos Pro Ltd is. **It is not just special but much more.**



Every designer for his own?

Almost every designer of audio component(s) is a music lover to begin with.

They have an audio system at home and spent some times with it to enjoy the music they love. Then they found something is not right with certain component but realize that the better component out there is beyond them or that nothing is good enough. Then, in their free time, the mission begins to design that component to sound the way they want or to them, suppose to sound.

After some months or years, the creation births forth (I am sure that was how *Victor Frankenstein made his monster*).

At first, that creation is purely for his own consumption but then some friends came over and heard it.

The encouragements came and courage built up.



Thus, the business began.

This story was told to me or I have read it somewhere, the beginning of almost every designer. I respect that. Hence, when any of them come into my audio room and claim his creation is the best et all, I tend to give them the benefit of the doubt. But, they are those that push further and claim that the others' are just wrong in design or sound. There is always the old saying, 'the taste is in the pudding'.

Louis Desjardins' beginning is of no difference with the others, confident in his design and the way he perceives musical playback. He has a strong sense for musical playback. Being an audiophile for so many years, collector of many fine records, loudspeakers and much exposure to reel to reel playback.

Thus, he ***emphasizes and believes in the energy stored in the music, may it be emotion, artistry, or soul***, and that must be able to portray or project out through an audio system starting with the source component, the turntable.

He believes that the music must be able to express herself through the audio system or at least, as much as possible. He wants the *musical playback experience to be as **native and raw to the actual performance or the master tape***.

The list of what Louis seeks in an audio system can go on and on. I can assure you it's not a short list. I can assure you too that my list is not short either after being an audiophile traveling on this high end journey for so many years. I think you know where I am going with this story. Both of us are fanatical with our hobby.



When Vision, Design and Reality meet...the MAN?!

When you listen to the Kronos Pro Ltd, you are listening to Louis Desjardins' vision of what musical presentation through a turntable which in turn through an audio system suppose to be.

Every designer will tell you the same but is his vision yours? Thus born the colors in presentation and the beauty thereof.

Kronos Pro Ltd is designed to be '**the most**' "**balance**" **turntable** that its designer is able to conceive. The *counter rotation concept, the suspensions, the bearing, motors system, materials used, the selection of belts, the electronic, power supply and the clamp (I hope nothing is miss out)* are well thought out here to provide a package of a turntable that is "balance(d)".

The counter rotation platters in this turntable alone is a fascination to behold. I can testify to you it's really more

impressive when you test the effectiveness of it. Louis told me that there are many turntables designs aim to provide the lowest noise rotating platter in the audio market. You just have to land your stylus at the groove of a rotating vinyl record on that turntable and you will know how quiet it is.

The Kronos Pro Ltd will have you hear almost nothing as the stylus land at the groove of the record.



It's that quiet!

I have always thought the TechDas Air Force One turntable is the quietest turntable in this regard but it is quiet to the extent of a very slight 'thumb noise' as the stylus lands into the groove.

I have to quantify that the above result is attainable with proper alignment and set up of the cartridge with the tone arm et al.

The suspensions in this turntable is another equally impressive feature.

Have the Kronos Pro Ltd sit on a stable platform without any 'active and aggressive' resonance or vibration control. This is to allow only the suspensions at the turntable to work. Then knock at that platform or the entire rack for that matter, you will not hear anything through the loudspeakers. It's dead quiet here! I am sure many well designed turntables will give you quite similar effect, but still not really there.

(Please do not knock the turntable off the platform to [dis]prove this point – your money.)

I have the TechDas Air Force One turntable for more than a year and have played it to most of my audiophile friends. They are always impressed with its performance (there is no question there). There is a 'but' here.

The time that is required to wait for the platter to rotate to speed is a test of patience. I have to say that I am mightily impressed with the stability and accuracy of the speed of the TechDas turntables even in situation of *irregular voltage*. I love to use the *Sutherland Timeline* to prove the accuracy and stability of the turntable platter rotational speed.

*Here, I will have you know that **my champion turntable in speed and stability, the TechDas Air Force One, is challenged by the Kronos Pro Ltd, where it will get the same result in much (much) lesser time.***

Further testing the quietness of the Kronos...

I am sure that many believe in the importance of the turntable and maybe more in the sound characteristics of a cartridge, but few do emphasize the game changing effect of a tone arm, in the ultimate result of an analogue system. I believe, only fairly recently, that prominent and profound design efforts are spent on a tonearm. We have some new found gems here, ie; Vertere Reference, Swedish Analogue Technologies (SAT) {both of which I have reviewed here}, Thales, Schroeder, Acoustical System Germany, and etc. Among these greats, I have the

pleasure to try out three (3), namely, the Vertere Reference, SAT and The Aquilar of Acoustical System, Germany on the TechDas Air Force One. All the tonearms were having similar selection of cartridges, notably, TriangleArt Apollo MC and Koetsu Blue Lace Platinum.



I could not believe the differences that each tonearm is able to provide to the ultimate result. I have heard the differences a tonearm contribute at other turntables set up such as the Linn Sondek, Michel GryoDec, TWAs, SME 30/2, VPIs, and etc, with tonearms such as SME V, Graham(s), Triplaner, Breuer, Reeds, Linn(s), Rega(s), Kuzma and etc.

The differences are notable there, but not at the level the TechDas Air Force One is able to allow each combination of tonearm to soar (up high or low). As I went through the combinations, I can easily pick up the characteristics of each component in it. Thus, I believe it is ***the quietness or lack of noise at the turntable that have allowed such differences to be clearly audible and felt.***

At a much (much) lower price point compared to the TechDas Air Force One, the Kronos Pro Ltd has more similarities than dissimilarities. It will be that turntable, as above, allowing the listener to experience the differences of each tonearm and cartridge combination clearly.



Question: How could it be louder since having the same tonearm, cartridge and the rest of the audio system?

I'd asked Louis, and his reply to me was that the counter rotation of the platters at the Kronos Pro Ltd coupled with the other properties in the design allowed the cartridge to be able to dig and extract more into the low of each note. He believe that *it is not louder in term of volume but **each note has been given a "fuller being" or completeness.***

I played a simple vocal accompanied by a piano track from the album, "**Fairy Tales**" (Odin LP03). Here, I *find **each piano key is more complete** than any I have heard in my audio system. To me, I have been handed the full key and note **with all its intended strength, energy and the full bandwidth from top to low.***

In addition, there is a certain low to each key as if **each key is given a 'full stop' at the bottom.** I have shared in previous review about piano key being given a lower bandwidth as if **each note is given a leg or is being anchored.**

The Kronos Pro Ltd will give you **the "feet" to that 'leg' of each key and note** in the presentation. To me, this is not additional bass line to a note but **an actual tail end of a note** that most top end turntables missed.

"Any additional information that I can hear from a recording, I would treat so as additional resolution. But any additional or exaggeration of any particular frequency, I would treat it as coloration".

Here, the **humane and seductive voice of Ms. Toneff** will further enlightened us. Previously, I am already accustomed and treated to a **fluid, natural, and well detailed and textured voice**, as if I am being fed **directly from the recording mike.**

The Kronos Pro Ltd will take the same combination a few notches higher or more. I could have swear that I heard her sang with **greater depth and breath.** She is drawing more breath and able to sing the **notes with higher energy.** The **transient of energy and dynamism** in her voice was so vivid, and palpable at the same time. It was a **more emotional presentation.**

In addition, each sentence sang clearly carried with it **a tail to an end.** You are able to follow the *last word's exaggeration to an end.*

The full stop at that sentence is clearly sang out. I think you notice the repetition of the same point here that I wish to indicate *a hint of the magnitude of how impressed I am (!)*.

The detailing of the vocal continued with an **audible echo-like to each word** sang. I believe that was the venue being recorded (I am not pointing at the duplicity effect of the recording at the studio). It was **the reverb of her voice from the recording venue that was picked up by the mike.** The other top notch turntables are able to draw out this detail but not obvious enough for me to draw up a conclusion as to its origin.

Next, I like to bring up **Sarah McLachlan's Mirrorball (45 rpm from Analogue Productions APP 053-45).** The track '**Angel**' recorded live is my new found favorite. I found her singing of this track to be particularly touching and filled with emotion. Her voice kept me wanting for more.

The sense of *emotions flowing* through those lyrics kept me entangled, to say the very least. The Kronos Pro Ltd has that capturing and rendering of the recorded human voice that the other turntables in my arsenal, though great they are in this same area, tend to slack a notch behind. The others will have that *human vocal with her prominency* but may lack slightly that '**emotional pull**'. I felt the emotional pull is at that **energy level** recorded **that contained in that voice.** I even, felt the **additional low frequency** that was extracted for that voice that gave a **certain rawness to the voice.**

The other turntables will give you the *voice, artistries and emotion* of the vocalist but I find the Kronos Pro Ltd will give slightly more of that vocalist. It is as if you can **feel her life and essence in the performance.** That is what I felt and heard in *the difference between analogue and digital.*

Similarly, I found to be the same between vinyl and good reel to reel tape. This really set the Kronos Pro Ltd apart from the rest.



"To me, the Kronos Pro Ltd has that similarity in character and energy with the playback of 1/4" reel to reel tapes".

Louis has shared to me that his turntable is used at **HD Tracks** to *evaluate and compare between the reel to reel tapes with their vinyl counterpart.*

Depending on the quality and generation of the reel to reel tape, it is not always better than the vinyl counterpart. HD Tracks have tried a number of other turntables available to them and decided to have the Kronos Pro Ltd. I believe there is a good reason for it.

Comparatively, it is ***THE TURNTABLE that is able to present that extra octave at the low that ultimately affect the energy level, the rawness or directness of a presentation.***

When I listened to *1/4" reel to reel tape*, always expect *additional level of detail, energy, low bass and resolution* that is in the recording. I can hear the *similarities* with the Kronos Pro Ltd.

Here, I emphasize '***similarities***' as I have no reel to reel tape player in my arsenal to compare and that my experience is limited to those at my friend's set up and at show.

The ***extra low octave*** retrieved can be put to test through the **Opus 3 Test Record 1 Depth of Image (Opus 3 79-00)**. I realized that *the soundstage depth, width and to a certain extent, the height benefitted from the retrieval of the extra low octave*. Here, I can hear and experience the soundstage at a *very different level*. It is as if the ***performers were given more space to perform***. Their *respective size and musical instrument(s) did not grow bigger but only the space or room has been enlarged*.

Thus, there are ***more clearer and distinct separation*** among the performers and also with their respective choice of musical instruments. This also allow me to hear more into each performance.

As I have shared above, notes have a certain completeness that I accredited to the retrieval of additional low. Here, I can ***hear more into the musical instruments played***. It's not just the performance but *the actual material of the musical instrument*. Each musical instrument enjoy a certain '***wholeness***' and each note played has its '***completeness***' through this turntable.

If this phenomenon is merely the result of the retrieval of extra low then I would sum up that the design properties of this turntable has hit the right note that others have missed. It can be said, that through the Kronos

Pro Ltd, you can hear more into the whole performance.

Ultimately, I felt closer to the presentation.



Enter the Titans

To be frank, I thought I have heard it all through the other turntables in my arsenal especially through the *TechDas Air Force One* and the Clearaudio Statement. Both of them are considered “**One of the Best (!)**” turntables in the market. I am sure there are those whom may not agree, which is fine. I own and heard them.

To me, these turntables and others in this category of turntable Titans strive to do one thing. That is to *bring out every last ounce of details* buried in the grooves of the vinyl records that we love and cherish. The question is how much detail is buried there. It seems to me that there is always a new Titan emerges and claims to allow more details to be heard. I realized that the *so called more detail is not really more in the sense of a new tone to the music*, especially **among these Titans**. It is more of the ‘energy stored in the music’ that is in the grooves. The *Clearaudio Statement* and **Transrotor Artus** are great examples in this regard.

A listen to them will immediately strike you as to the amount of energy contained in any music.



“We did not really know the recording well enough”, was my thought then.

I sacrificed much to put my order for a Clearaudio Statement (then). The *TechDas Air Force One* was not in the

league of energy as those Titans. I admit that the TechDas has its *other titanic property* which is *low noise floor* that is transparent to the source “above the true subsonic low”, to the extreme high. Don’t get me wrong, the TechDas is no slouch in the attack department with low bass that is very articulated, defined, control and fill with detail.

In many audio system, especially with mid size loudspeaker system, the TechDas will do impressively. Most listeners will not miss or notice the loss of subsonic low (since most loudspeakers designs are not meant to play those low frequencies)

Try to play big band or big orchestra such as **Count Basie and his orchestra, “Me and You” (Pablo 2310-891).** The *Clearaudio Statement* is **“truly majestic”** when it comes to presenting the ***foundation of a grand musical presentation.***

I am not emphasizing the *subsonic low bass alone* but there are many *other elements* in the recorded music that *must be retrieved in order to bear “such fruit”.*

I am thrilled and surprised that the Kronos Pro Ltd is definitely doing its task right in order to ***bear “similar fruit” with such Titan, the Clearaudio Statement.*** It definitely allow the ***retrieval of the subsonic low (and other elements) as much as the Clearaudio Statement.***



There is still a difference between the Kronos and the Clearaudio.

If push to compare, I find and prefer the Kronos in its presentation of the ‘***wholeness***’ of the musical instrument and the ‘***completeness***’ of the tone.

I believe that the Kronos has a ***lower noise floor*** than the Clearaudio that resulted the above, thus shifted my preference among the two turntables.

My conviction for my finding is further reinforced after I heard those ***musical instruments that are at the recessed background (also) enjoyed the same ‘wholeness’ as those at the foreground, and with the same ‘completeness’ of tone.***



A Titan's Task(s)

The turntable Titans must be great as a source in both ***low and high volume quality playback***. I must quantify that high volume quality playback is not just a matter of 'decibel loudness'.

In actuality, in my book anyway, the *high volume quality playback* will showcase many "crucial factors" that hold the entire music together and ability to maintain its essence and meaning.

I love to pick up the **Manger Production vinyl album, "Musik wei von einem anderen Stern" (AMGR 2010)** and have it play loud (peaked at 100dB, plus a few more dB), especially with the following tracks; '**Walking on the Moon**' and '**Jazz Variants**'.

Many thought that playing loud and without any distortion or breakdown is the true test of high fidelity.

I did hope it was that easy. I notice many system (even very expensive ones) that *as they play loud, they start to lose integrity and solidity to the imaging*. Even the *separation between images or musicians in the recording start to close up*.

To me, the *soundstage is actually shrinking in proportion and ratio* in relation to actual separation between musicians in the recording. The *imaging grows larger or bloater* as the volume goes higher. This occurs all too often.

I notice the real top end sources will not perform so. Here, the Kronos Pro Ltd will allow you to ***hear louder*** but ***maintain the images of the recorded musician in place within the soundstage and in proportion***.

In addition, *each image maintain its own wholeness, palpability, solidity and density*. All in all, each image ***maintain its integrity thus realism*** in the soundstage of the recording venue.

I believe *this quality is even more important for the playback of a big band*. Some will accredit this quality to the low noise floor of the turntable which I have no argument here.

However, I wish to add that the Kronos Pro Ltd will give the presentation an even ***more solidity, strength and energy to each performer's performance and more realism to the musical instrument played*** than the few top "Turntable Titans" in my arsenal.





A TRUE TITAN.

I have the Kronos Pro Ltd turntable in my audio system for about two months already. It has been playing almost on a daily basis in comparison with the other turntables in my keep. I admit that this is one ***"tough review"*** to write.

It is difficult not in term of identifying the differences between the "Turntable Titans", but an ***"emotional one"***. Comparing them in my ownership is like comparing my children. I paid a great deal for each and every one of them.

A lot of time and energy were spent to tweak them to perform to ***"my level of expectation"***.

In term of ***quality audio performance***, I find the Kronos Pro Ltd (with my combination of tonearm and cartridge) *is in the league of the very best turntable out in the audio market, to say the least.*

However, in actual comparison, I find it having a ***few notches above the TechDas Air Force One and the Clearaudio Statement***, which are considered to be at the very top category of *Turntable Design* and *Quality Product*. If one wish to argue he prefer one turntable's character and coloration of presentation over the other then there isn't much I can argue.

It remained that the Kronos Pro Ltd's strength in the ***retrieval of detail, even at that subsonic low***, and at ***lower noise floor*** than the other Titans in my keep.

In addition, it does '***bass***' at a ***"whole new improved level"*** that have a positive attribute to the actual presentation of the ***"wholeness and completeness"*** of the musical presentation, at a ***soundstage that represent the venue of recording.***

Currently, I have yet to hear a better turntable than the Kronos Pro Ltd.

As for the ***price of admission*** to the Kronos Pro Ltd, I would say that it is a ***"No Brainer"*** choice, irrespective of budget. I own some of its competitors, namely the *TechDas Air Force One* and the *Clearaudio Statement* which cost several times its cost but they do *not give me any higher performance value.*

In conclusion, the Kronos Pro Ltd is correctly named after the supreme god in Greek mythology. I think Louis knew the conclusion from the very beginning.





Associated audio components in this review:

- 1) TriangleArt Apollo MC cartridge,
- 2) Koetsu Blue Lace cartridge,
- 3) Ortofon MC Anna cartridge,
- 4) My Sonic Lab Eminent BC cartridge,
- 5) ZYX Omega Gold cartridge,
- 6) Vertere Reference tonearm,
- 7) Miyajima Kansui cartridge,
- 8) SoundSmith Strain Gauge,
- 9) Graham Phantom 2 tonearm (9"),
- 10) Breuer tonearm,
- 11) Aquilar 10" tonearm, Acoustical System, Germany
- 12) TechDas Air Force One turntable,
- 13) Kronos Pro Limited production turntable,
- 14) Linn Sondek turntable with Lingo powered,
- 15) Clearaudio Statement turntable & dedicated Statement linear arm,
- 16) FM Acoustics 223 Phono Master stage,
- 17) Vitus Masterpiece Phonostage MP-P201,
- 18) FM Acoustics 268C pre amp,
- 19) Vitus Masterpiece Pre amp MP-L201,
- 20) Vitus Masterpiece Mono Amplifier MP-M201,
- 21) Gryphon Pendragon Loudspeaker System,
- 22) Skogrand Beethoven Loudspeaker cables,
- 23) Skogrand Tchaikovsky Balance interconnects,
- 24) Vermouth Red Velvet XLRs,
- 25) Gobel Lacorde Statement XLR,
- 26) Gobel Lacorde Statement Power cord,
- 27) Shunyata King Cobra Power cords,
- 28) Shunyata V Ray 1 & 2 Power Distribution,
- 29) Frank Acoustics Power Bank Storage PB-15000Ws (6 units),
- 30) Nordost QX (2 units),
- 31) Tombo Audio platforms,